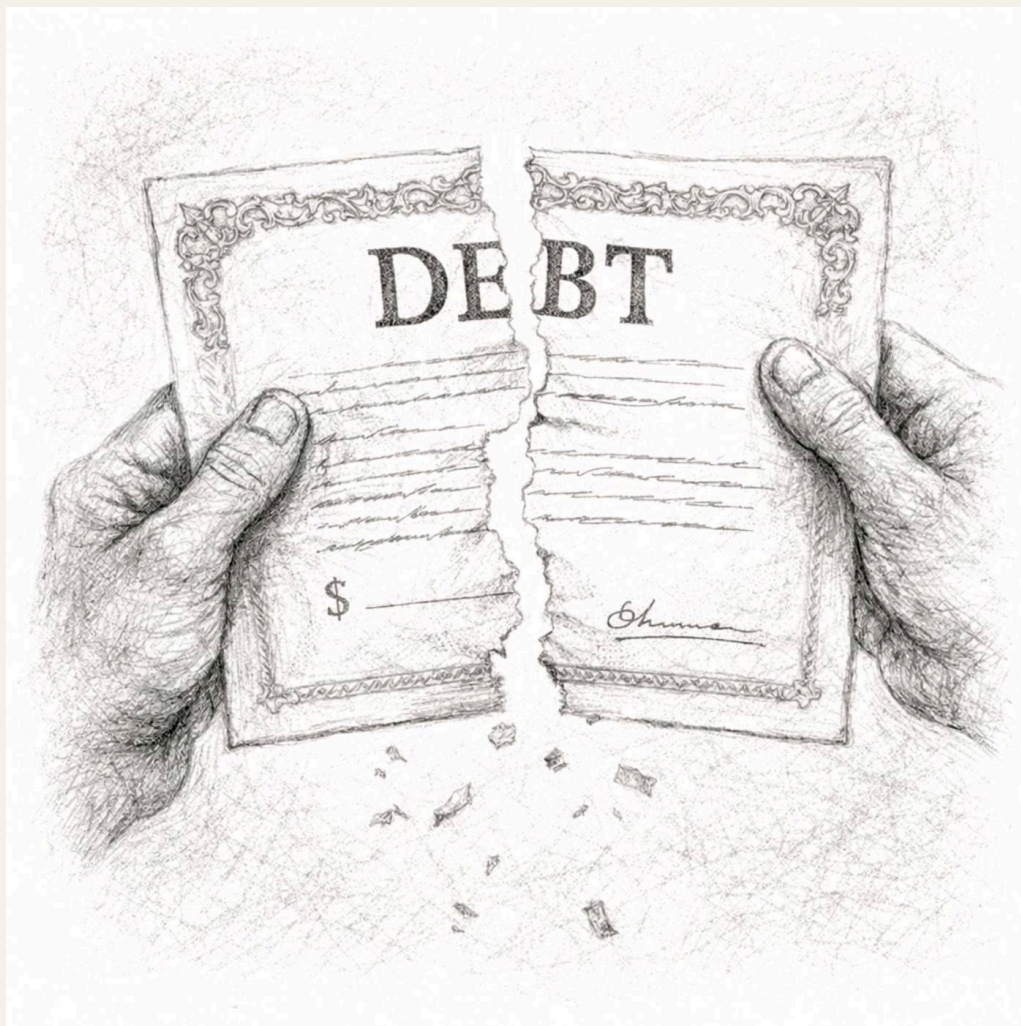


Forgiveness



Two hands tear a sheet that says DEBT. The rip is down the middle. Scraps fall. Forgiveness is not a payment plan. The paper does not get taped back together.

Before you gather

- Read Day 19, Forgiveness, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Luke 7:41–48 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 · ICEBREAKER · 7 MIN

Open the room

What bill or reminder would you love to see stamped paid and gone?

Leader. A real debt, cancelled. Then open Luke 7. Jesus talks about two debtors, and a woman who knows she was forgiven much. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 · THE WORD · 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Forgiveness means God cancels the debt of sin in Christ and does not hold it against His people. The debt was real. The cross paid it.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Forgiveness is the gracious act of God by which He fully pardons sinners of their guilt, cancels their debt of sin, and no longer holds their transgressions against them because of Christ's work on the cross.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek *aphesis* — release, pardon, the cancellation of a debt.

MEMORY VERSE · COLOSSIANS 1:14

In whom we have redemption, the forgiveness of sins.

Together, open the flashcard for Forgiveness. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 · OPEN THE BIBLE · 15 MIN

Luke 7:41–48

Colossians 1:14 is the memory verse. Stay in Luke 7:41–48. Forgiveness is a cancelled debt, and it shows up in love for Jesus.

“A certain moneylender had two debtors. One owed five hundred denarii, and the other fifty. When they could not pay, he cancelled the debt of both. Now which of them will love him more?” Simon answered, “The one, I suppose, for whom he cancelled the larger debt.” And he said to him, “You have judged rightly.” ... And he said to her, “Your sins are forgiven.” Then those who were at table with him began to say among themselves, “Who is this, who even forgives sins?” And he said to the woman, “Your faith has saved you; go in peace.”

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. In the parable, what is different about the two debtors, and what is the same? CORE

Leader. One owed more. Both could not pay. The lender cancelled both debts. The difference is not that one was able. Neither could pay.

2. Jesus asks who will love the lender more. What does He say about the woman, and what does He say to her?

Leader. She loved much because she was forgiven much. He says, “Your sins are forgiven... Your faith has saved you; go in peace.” Faith, not her tears, saved her. The tears showed she knew the debt.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Colossians 2:13–14 says God cancelled the record of debt by nailing it to the cross. Where did the record go?

Leader. To the cross. It was not ignored. It was nailed there in Christ. Without the shedding of blood there is no forgiveness.

4. Matthew 6:14–15 and Ephesians 4:32 belong together. Why do forgiven people forgive? CORE

Leader. Because God in Christ forgave them. We do not forgive to earn His forgiveness. We forgive because we have received it. Do not reverse that.

5. Who are you still charging for a debt Christ has told you to release? What will you do this week?

Leader. Name a grudge without a long story. Cancel it. If the person does not know Christ, tell them God cancels sin's debt in Jesus.

5 · SAY IT · 5 MIN

In one sentence

Forgiveness means God cancels our debt of sin in Christ and does not hold it against us.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 · THIS WEEK · 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Release a real grudge against someone outside the church — stop retelling the story, stop charging them. Tell them you are letting it go because God cancels sin's debt in Christ. Invite them to Jesus.

Leader. Forgiveness is not saying the wound was fine. It is laying down the right to punish. Say that before they leave. Do not tell an unbeliever they are already forgiven if they will not

have Christ. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Father, thank You for cancelling a debt we could not pay.
2. Forgive us for keeping books You have closed.
3. Help us forgive one person this week, and to tell them about Jesus.

Before you stumble

Do not say “forgive yourself.” The text has a Lender, and He cancels the debt. Also do not say forgiveness means there was no wrong. Luke 7 is about a real debt. And do not tell the room that tears save. Jesus says, “Your faith has saved you.”

WITH STUDENTS

Ask which debtor they are, the one who owed more or the one who owed less. Then say both could not pay. That is the point. Christ paid.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Psalms 103:12. As far as the east is from the west, so far does He remove our transgressions from us. Read it as praise, not as a new lesson.